Alina *Acosta*-Romay

DIRECTOR OF OPERATIONS & PEOPLE · SYSTEMS BUILDER · NONPROFIT & SME · TRILINGUAL EN/FR/ES

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PROFILE

Operations and people leader with **15+ years** building systems, processes, and organizational infrastructure in SME, nonprofit, and startup environments — **from scratch.**

CORE SKILLS

Operations

- Operational Systems & Workflow Design
- Process Documentation
- Policy Development
- Vendor Management
- Tool Implementation

Finance

- Budgeting & Forecasting
- Financial Controls
- P&L Management
- Reporting Automation
- Grant & Funder Reporting

People & HR

- Team Leadership
- Recruitment & Onboarding
- Performance Management
- Culture-Building
- Training & Development

Compliance

PROFESSIONAL EXPERIENCE

General Manager

Apr 2024 – May 2025

Nature Expert · Montreal, QC

Quebec's leading specialty birding retailer — $1.8M annual revenue, 5-person team, 700+ SKUs. Owner absent 8+ months. No documented processes, no operational infrastructure. French first environment.

- Built and ran the full organizational infrastructure independently during an 8+ month leadership gap — staff scheduling, supplier management, inventory governance, order fulfillment, financial decision-making, and customer escalations simultaneously with **zero disruptions.**
- Led a **5-person team** across retail and e-commerce: managed scheduling, performance conversations, conflict resolution, and day-to-day team culture during a period of sustained uncertainty and no executive oversight.
- Recruited, onboarded, and trained a replacement manager from scratch — built the onboarding documentation, process playbooks, and knowledge transfer system that allowed a clean operational handoff.
- Built operational processes and documentation where none existed: buying cadences, supplier protocols, fulfillment workflows, and financial reporting templates — **took the business from informal systems to repeatable, transferable infrastructure**.
- Led **technology implementation** to ensure operational continuity past my exit: built an Excel-based accounting and monthly P&L automation protocol; introduced HubSpot for marketing planning, content scheduling, and posting workflows; set up Slack for direct team communication; rebuilt the customer newsletter on Mailchimp; managed the e-commerce platform on OpenCart; and introduced an AI-assisted content repurposing system to transform 15+ years of archived birding newsletters into fresh community content.
- Oversaw vendor relationships with 20+ suppliers — managed contracts, negotiations, payment terms, and compliance; **resolved disputes independently**.

Data Governance | Risk Management | Regulatory Compliance | Employment Standards | Organizational Policy

Tools

Excel (Advanced) | Power BI | QuickBooks | Shopify | CRM (HubSpot/Salesforce) | Trello | Google Workspace | Tableau

LANGUAGES

English — Native

French — Professional

Spanish — Native

EDUCATION

Master of Arts, Economics (30 credits completed)
University of Ottawa · 2014–2017

BA Honours, Economics — Top 10%
University of Calgary · 2013

BA, International Relations
University of Calgary · 2013

HACCP Certification (2018)

COMMUNITY

Queer woman, parent of a trans young man, and loving support system to many 2SLGBTQIA+ people.

- Cut fulfillment costs **33% ($39K/year)** by rebuilding the cost model and renegotiating carrier rates; redesigned pricing across 165 SKUs based on margin analysis and competitive data.
- Stopped a 4-year revenue decline — both 2024 and 2025 had growth.

Growth & Financial Strategy Consultant

Jul 2025 – Feb 2026

Nature Expert · Montreal, QC

Returned to build financial infrastructure and complete the strategic growth plan.

- **Rebuilt 4 years of monthly P&Ls** from bank ledgers — corrected expense misclassifications, built category-level reporting, and gave the organization its first real view of margin, seasonality, and cost drivers by channel and SKU.
- Built reporting automation, reducing monthly P&L compilation from 25–30 hrs to 5–6 hrs (**80% reduction**) — enabled monthly financial reviews instead of annual.
- Designed and modeled an Open-to-Buy inventory governance system with monthly budgets, seasonality-based allocation, and hard-stop rules — identified **~$150K annual gross profit improvement;** delivered as a ready-to-implement framework.
- Identified **$600K+** in recoverable revenue across pricing, shipping policy, conversion, dead stock, and idle capital — sequenced by impact and feasibility into a phased implementation plan.
- Produced a full organizational diagnostic across 7 documents — financial analysis, strategic idea matrix, and **6-engine growth model** — synthesized into a 3-year roadmap for increasing yearly revenue to $2.5M+.

Business Development Manager – Quebec & Nunavut

CQCC – Canadian Queer Chamber of Commerce · Montreal, QC

Mar 2025 – Jun 2025

Nonprofit advocacy and entrepreneurship organization serving 2SLGBTQI+ business owners across Canada — grant-funded, mission-driven, bilingual.

- Led the Supplier Diversity Certification program for Quebec and Nunavut — surpassed enrollment targets, **onboarding 8 new 2SLGBTQI+ entrepreneurs** into the certification pipeline.
- Delivered bilingual (EN/FR) business coaching to SME founders on operations, pricing, **go-to-market strategy, product-market-fit, and revenue growth**.
- Operated in a **grant-funded** nonprofit environment: tracked program deliverables, managed reporting timelines, and aligned activities to funder expectations and compliance requirements.

Founder & Product Developer

May 2018 – Mar 2025

Nutality Foods Inc. · Montreal, QC

Built 3 CPG product lines from formulation through retail distribution — managed all operations, finances, supply chain, and external collaborators simultaneously.

- Managed a distributed network of external collaborators — nutritionists, food scientists, packaging designers, co-packers, regulatory consultants, and retail brokers — coordinating timelines, deliverables, and compliance across all relationships without a formal team structure.
- Built all internal systems from scratch in a **startup environment**: financial tracking, vendor governance, inventory management, pricing models, and distribution documentation.
- Tested initial brand (CookieTella) in-store; identified positioning mismatch through direct consumer observation; **rebuilt brand from scratch** — new name, identity, and target demographic — validated before relaunch.
- Raised **$85K** through validated investor pitch decks and financial models; built retail distribution from 0 to **40+ retail accounts** through cold approach and relationship building.

Market Research & Strategy Consultant

Trade Facilitation Office of Canada (TFO Canada) · Ottawa, ON

Feb 2017 – May 2018

Non-profit organization delivering trade facilitation programs to international SMEs — government-funded, bilingual, compliance-driven.

- Produced market entry research reports for international SMEs across food, textiles, technology, and construction — deliverables tied directly to **federal funding mandates and program outcome reporting**.
- Managed reporting timelines and deliverable compliance aligned to government funder requirements — operated within structured accountability frameworks typical of **grant-funded organizations**.
- Represented TFO Canada at SIAL Montreal 2018 — supported **40+ entrepreneurs** from developing countries attending the show, helping them connect with Canadian buyers and distributors to secure market entry and future sales. Prepared supporting documents and presentations for the event. Walked the show floor to collect trend data on the Canadian food industry, which I later synthesized into an updated market report delivered to TFO stakeholders.
- Used Excel, Tableau, and Nielsen I to analyze consumer demand, pricing structures, and market positioning opportunities; produced **trilingual (EN/FR/ES)** reports and stakeholder materials.

International Market Expansion Manager

Aug 2016 – Jan 2017

The Rainforest Company · Ottawa, ON

- Grew B2B customer base from 0 to 30+ accounts; **expanded product portfolio** from 4 to 20+ SKUs; navigated CFIA compliance and import requirements for South American food products.

Business Development Specialist

Dec 2014 – Sep 2015

Allied Scientific Pro · Gatineau, QC

- Achieved **highest** call-to-sale conversion on technical sales team; identified and opened new institutional market segments (museums and galleries) creating 8+ year client relationships.

EARLIER EXPERIENCE

Economic Energy Advisor
Embassy of the Republic of Korea to Canada · Ottawa, ON · 2015–2016

Energy Economics Intern
Kinder Morgan Canada · Calgary, AB · 2012

Project Officer, Innovation & IP
Innovate Calgary · Calgary, AB · 2013

Co-Founder, Farms To You Canada
Calgary, AB · 2006–2008. Wholesale fresh flower distribution; imported from Latin America, supplied Walmart, Co-Op Calgary, and 250+ florists.

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